MODULE 1
Teambuilding & Entrepreneurial Mindset

A joint initiative by

Check-In: How much new revenue did you sign? (0 is an honest answer — it won't stay 0 for long)

Today

Check-in — first numbers, honest zeros (10')

The 12-week program: rhythm, playbook, one paying customer (10')

IDEA 1 · Startup ≠ small business — ambition with a wedge (15')

IDEA 2 · Teams beat ideas (10')

IDEA 3 · Co-founder fit is testable (10')

IDEA 4 · Candor from day one (10')

Case · BioNTech: the team that waited 12 years to be right (30')

Workshop · Problem Safari — leave the building (90')

Wrap-up · team + 3 ranked problem hypotheses (5')

VENTURE LABS

The 12-Week Playbook

A joint initiative by

UNTERNEHMER TUM

The Weekly Rhythm



SHIP SOMETHING EVERY WEEK -- NO EXCEPTIONS



TALK TO 10-15 USERS MINIMUM PER WEEK



RUN AT LEAST ONE VALIDATION EXPERIMENT PER WEEK



REFLECT AND ITERATE BASED ON EVIDENCE, NOT OPINIONS



DOCUMENT EVERYTHING IN YOUR EVIDENCE PACK

Everything takes twice as long as you want it to

10.000 LinkedIn Impressions



1.000 website visitors



100 Interviews



10 Demos



1 paying customer

Only paying customers are real validation. Everything else is opinions.

IDEA 1: Startup ≠ small business

A startup is a company designed to grow fast — that choice changes everything: market, team, funding, pace.

Think moonshot, start wedge: Stripe wanted to move the GDP of the internet — and began with 7 lines of code.

Startup vs. Small Business

Small Business

Optimize for lifestyle

Steady, linear growth

Local or niche market

Bootstrap mindset

Example: Restaurant, Agency

Startup

Optimize for growth

Exponential trajectory

Global or scalable market

Venture-scale ambition

Example: Airbnb, Stripe

Paul Graham, 'Startup = Growth': A startup is a company designed to grow fast.

Speed Is Your Only Advantage

Google has more money, people, and resources than you

But you can make decisions in minutes, not months

You can ship in days, not quarters

You can talk to users directly, not through layers of management

Your competitive advantage IS speed -- protect it ruthlessly

Paul Graham, 'Startup = Growth' (2012)

Focus matters:

Ship Relevant

But…

~~But I‘m not an engineer…~~

Yes, you can build it!

~~But we don‘t have a GmbH…~~

Yes, you can ship it!

Bold Vision + Precise First Problem

Not a contradiction — you need both, at the same time

BOLD VISION — the destination

- Your 10-year ambition — big enough to matter
- Attracts co-founders, talent and investors
- Survives pivots: problems change, direction stays
- Too big to build directly — that's the point

FIRST PROBLEM — the entry point

- One user group, one painful problem, this quarter
- Small enough to win in 12 weeks
- Creates paying customers — evidence, not opinion
- Each wedge you win expands toward the vision

A tiny first problem doesn't shrink your vision — it's how you earn the right to pursue it.

Stripe: Moonshot Vision, Tiny First Wedge

How the Collison brothers built a trillion-dollar-volume company from 7 lines of code

THE MOONSHOT (2010)

"Increase the GDP of the internet"

Payment infrastructure for the entire web economy

THE FIRST WEDGE

SF developers who couldn't accept payments:

weeks of bank paperwork vs. 7 lines of code

START

7 lines of code,
hand-onboarded users

→

FIRST USERS

Fellow YC startups —
a precise niche

→

EXPANSION

Developers worldwide,
then enterprises

→

TODAY

$1T+ processed
in a single year (2023)

The wedge made the moonshot credible: every YC startup that integrated Stripe was evidence, not opinion.

Moonshot AND wedge — same strategy, two zoom levels

The contradiction you'll feel: 'think big' (today) vs 'pick one tiny problem' (Module 3). It isn't one.

The VISION picks the mountain: market ceiling, why it matters, who joins you.

The WEDGE picks the first foothold: a problem so specific you can win it THIS semester.

Stripe, same week: 'grow the GDP of the internet' ↔ 'SF developers who can't accept payments'.

Vision without a wedge = pitch theater. Wedge without a vision = a feature, not a company. You need the pair.

IDEA 2: Teams beat ideas

Ideas are cheap and everywhere. Execution compounds weekly — and execution is a team property.

Investors read teams, not decks: complementary skills, shared conviction, evidence you ship.

Effective Founder Teams

A joint initiative by

What makes great founder teams?

Why Teams Beat Solo Founders

2-3 co-founders is optimal (YC data from 3,000+ startups)

Solo founders are 2x more likely to fail

Complementary skills > overlapping skills

Co-founders provide accountability and resilience

But: wrong co-founder is worse than no co-founder

First Round Capital: Founding teams with 2-3 people raise 30% more funding

The Ideal Founding Team

Builder: Can ship product fast (developer, designer)

Seller: Can get in front of customers (sales, marketing)

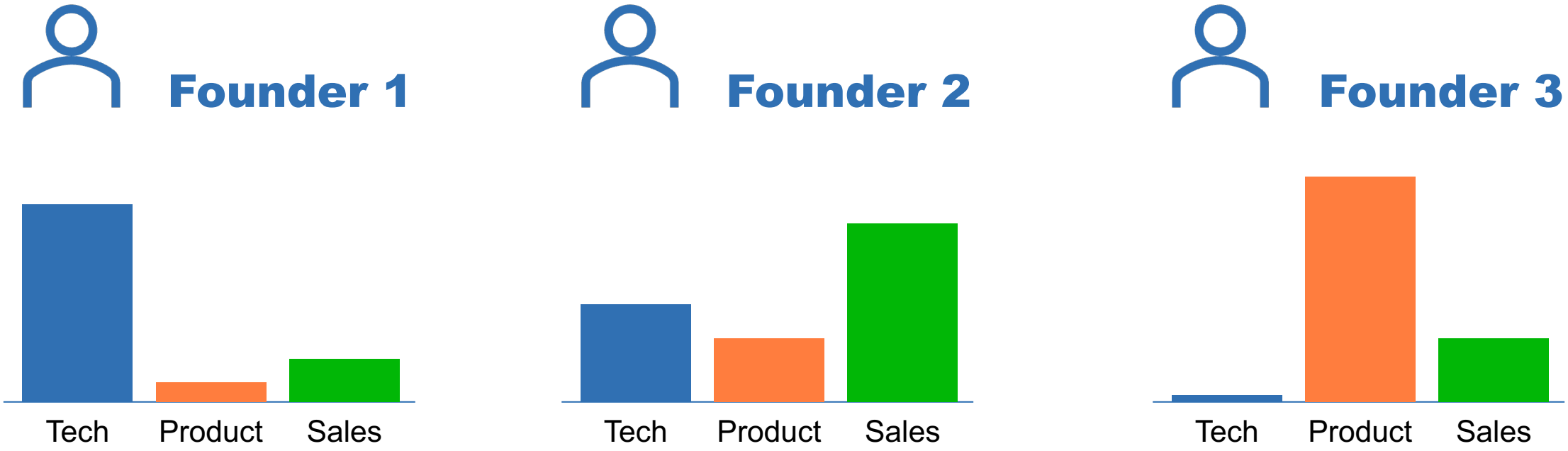
Domain Expert: Understands the problem deeply (optional)

Key: At least one person who can build, one who can sell

Avoid: All builders with no customer contact

YC Startup School, 2023

What you want in a team: Tech, Product, Sales



Show that you have the **Ability to Execute:**

Tech => Tech Stack, Tech Depth, Experience, …

Product => Target Audience, Target Market, Product Package, …

Sales => Industry Expertise, Industry Network, …

What the evidence says

Most founding teams form by attraction — friends and people like us. Research says: attraction-formed teams feel better and perform WORSE on skill coverage (Lazar et al. 2020, Academy of Management Annals).

Equity: teams that split quickly and equally to avoid the awkward talk regret it — negotiate roles first, shares second (Hellmann & Wasserman 2017; Wasserman, The Founder's Dilemmas).

Your homophily alarm: if your whole team can build but nobody can sell — today's Problem Safari is where you fix that.

IDEA 3: Co-founder fit is testable

You wouldn't marry after two coffees. Don't co-found after two beers.

Fit shows under load: test with a real project, talk equity and exit expectations EARLY, put it in writing.

Committing to a long term relationship

Communication Style

Needs

40%

dependent on relationship quality

Values

Energy

Expectations

Where to Find Co-Founders

Treat it like customer discovery: build a pipeline, don't wait for serendipity

1

Your existing network

Courses, thesis projects, student jobs, former colleagues — people you've already worked with are the strongest signal.

2

Ecosystem events & hackathons

HackaTUM, TechFest Munich, START Munich hack days, local meetups — watch people work under pressure before you commit.

3

Programs & communities

TUM Venture Labs, UnternehmerTUM, CDTM, Entrepreneur First, Antler — built to match complementary skill sets.

4

Online matching platforms

YC Co-Founder Matching (free, global), LinkedIn search in your problem space — filter hard, meet fast.

Aim for 10+ co-founder conversations before committing to one — you'd do the same for a key hire.

Where co-founders actually come from — Munich edition

This course. Look around — seriously. You'll see everyone here work under pressure for 12 weeks.

CDTM · UnternehmerTUM founder matching · TUM Venture Labs events — built exactly for this.

HackaTUM, START Munich, hackathons: watch people ship at 3am before you commit to them.

Clubs where people BUILD: WARR gave Munich Isar Aerospace (Module 2's case).

Online works too: YC Co-Founder Matching from Munich · EF/Antler if you want matching as a program.

The rule: choose from people you've SEEN work — not people you like at dinner.

Test the Partnership Before You Commit

The wrong co-founder is worse than no co-founder — so de-risk it like everything else

1

Run a trial project

2–4 weeks, one real deliverable (hackathon, mini validation sprint). Working style beats interview impressions.

2

Use the Co-Founder Matchmaking Assessment

Course toolkit: align on values, needs, working styles and communication — before any equity talk.

3

Have the hard conversations early

Equity split, time commitment, personal runway, what 'quit' looks like. Discomfort now saves the company later.

4

Check references

Talk to 2–3 people who've worked with them. Ask: 'Would you start a company with this person?'

5

Define a checkpoint

Agree on a 4-week review: continue, adjust, or part as friends. Vesting mindset from day one.

40% of the outcome depends on relationship quality — invest in it like you invest in your product.

Making Decisions Fast

Most decisions are reversible

Treat them that way. Don't agonize over two-way doors.

Disagree and commit

Once decided, everyone commits fully — no undermining.

Default to action

When in doubt, do something. Inaction is the riskiest choice in a startup.

Set decision deadlines

'We decide by Friday, or we default to X.'

One person owns each decision

No committee paralysis. Clear ownership, clear accountability.

Jeff Bezos, 2016 Letter to Shareholders: 'Disagree and Commit'

IDEA 4: Candor from day one

Teams don't die from conflict. They die from silence — polite, slow, fatal.

Radical candor: care personally, challenge directly. Installed now, while it's cheap.

Feedback and Candor

_GIVING FEEDBACK

_RECEIVING FEEDBACK

Giving Feedback – Creating the Message



DESCRIBE

Describe the situation you want to provide feedback on. Be as specific as possible. When and where did the situation take place?



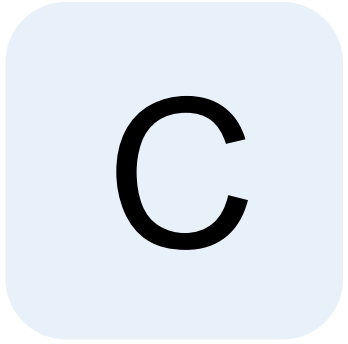
EXPRESS

Describe the behaviour that you observed. Stay here on the level of what you could actually perceive.



SPECIFY

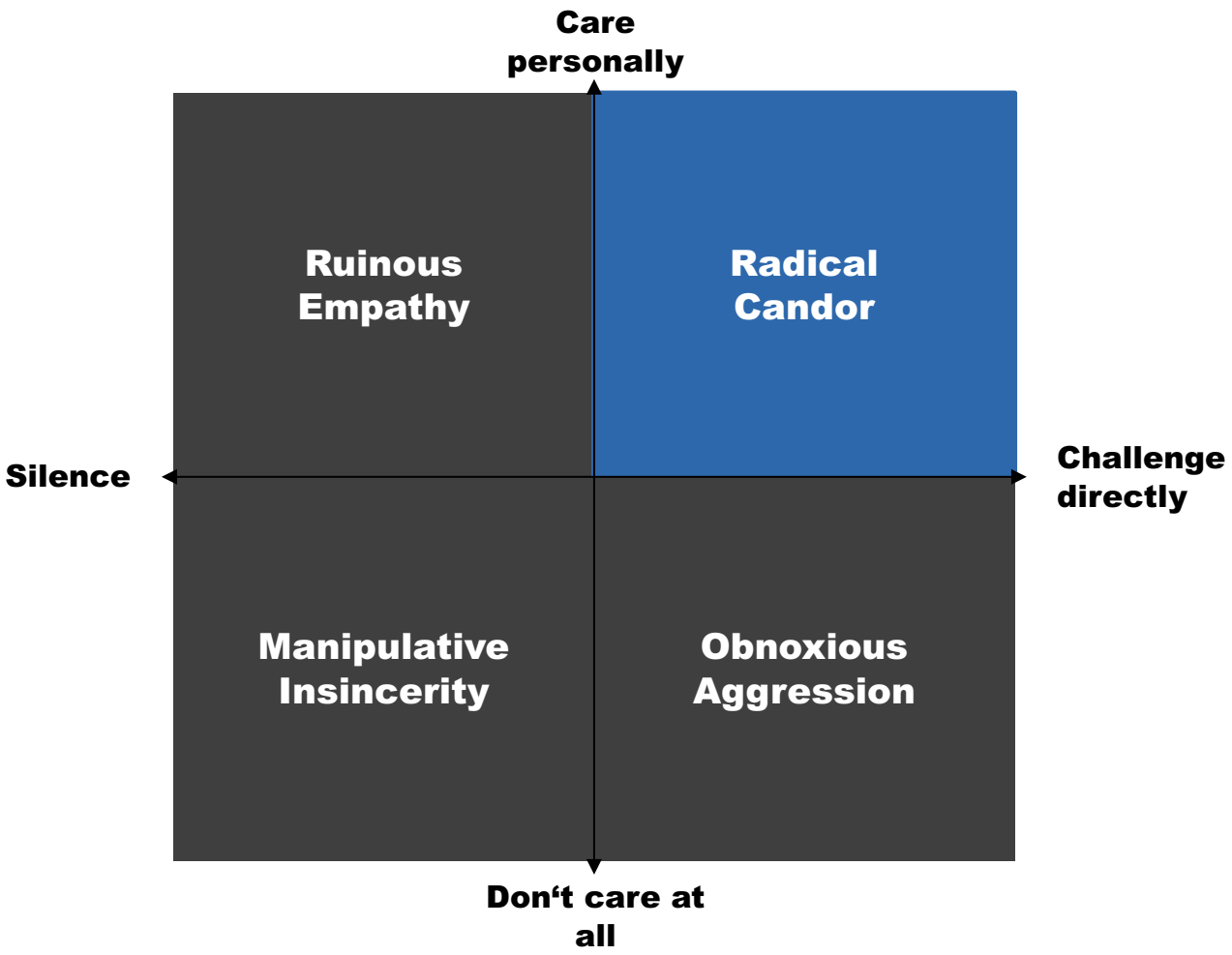
Describe the impact this behaviour has on you personally and/or the company.



CONSEQUENCES

Formulate a desired behaviour for the future.

Radical Candor: Giving the best possible Feedback



Radical Candor is the crossroads of **Challenging Directly** and **Caring Personally**:

Caring Personally: Radical Candor starts with caring about the person you're addressing. It involves building strong relationships with your team members based on trust, empathy, and genuine concern for their well-being.

Challenging Directly: This means being willing to provide honest, straightforward feedback, even if it's uncomfortable. It's about addressing issues directly and not shying away from difficult conversations.

END RECAP — today in four lines

1 · Startup means growth by design — moonshot vision, wedge-sized start

2 · Execution compounds; execution is a team property

3 · Test the partnership before you commit — roles first, equity second, in writing

4 · Radical candor installed now, while it's cheap

This week: 10 more real conversations, names + verbatim quotes in the Toolkit.

→ **Next week (Finding Ideas): your 10 conversations become the raw material for 20+ ideas — and ONE tested favorite.**

Workshop: Problem Safari (90 min)

Agenda lives in M01_Workshop_Problem-Safari.md. Rain plan included — the cafeteria counts as 'outside the building'.

Must produce: a formed team + 3 problem hypotheses ranked by conviction — from REAL conversations with strangers, today.

Kill criteria: your team formed around a cool technology instead of a real problem.

Wrapup & Checkout

Key Takeaways

NOW is the best time ever to start -- AI is your unfair advantage

Speed is your only edge over incumbents -- protect it

Teams of 2-3 with complementary skills outperform

Psychological safety enables fast iteration

Only paying customers are real validation

Where This Goes: Module 1 → 4

Every module's output is the next module's input

M1 · TODAY

Team formed +
3 problem hypotheses
ranked by conviction

→

M2 · IDEAS

Ideas stress-tested:
Crazy 8s → top 1 +
Mom Test script

→

M3 · PROBLEMS

5+ discovery interviews
→ Pain Map, JTBD,
hair-on-fire segment

→

M4 · VALIDATION

Landing page built from
customer language →
signups = evidence

By Module 4 you'll have: a team, a validated pain, and a list of people waiting for your solution.

This week — M01_Homework.md

1. Finalize your Team Charter
2. Each team member: Find 3 problems you personally experience
3. Brainstorm in your team about problems you know of or have
4. Decide on what kind of organization you want to create

Thank You!

A joint initiative by

APPENDIX — original slides (56 restored as images)

These pages from the pre-rework deck are not in the current flow. Source snapshot: Instructor/original-decks/M01_Lecture_ORIGINAL.pdf.

Mark each: KEEP (design pass rebuilds it properly, editable) or KILL. Nothing gets deleted without your call.

Check-In:

What is your Energy Level Today?

Check-In:

What was your most exciting finding?

Check-In:

What was your biggest road blocker?

Check-In:

How many users did you talk to?

Today's Learning Objectives

Understand why NOW is the best time to build a startup

Learn what separates successful founder teams from the rest

Build your team culture: feedback, speed, and psychological safety

Form your team and align on your first week's goals

Why is now the best time to start?

You‘re in the perfect storm

Ray Dalio‘s model for financial life cycles*:

Stage	Description	U.S. Timeline Example	Key Risks
1: New Order Established	A post-war reset crowns a new reserve currency and global leader, fostering stability.	1944 Bretton Woods Agreement: USD becomes world reserve after WWII.	None—honeym oon phase.
2: Peace and Productive Debt	Borrowing fuels innovation and growth; prosperity blooms.	1950s–1960s: Post-war boom, infrastructure investments.	Over-reliance on easy credit.
3: Debt Bubble and Wealth Gap	Excessive borrowing inflates assets; inequality surges as inflation erodes purchasing power for the masses.	1970s–2000s: Housing/credit boom widens the rich-poor divide.	Social unrest from disparity.
4: Bubble Burst and Downturn	Debt implodes, triggering recession.	2008 Financial Crisis: Subprime meltdown.	Systemic contagion.
5: Money Printing and Debasement	Central banks flood the system with liquidity (e.g., QE), but it widens gaps and erodes currency value.	2008–2020: Trillions printed; inflation hits the vulnerable hardest.	Currency devaluation, asset bubbles.
6: Internal Conflict and External Wars	Populism rises; civil strife weakens the empire, inviting rivals.	2020s onward: Polarization, tariffs, and great-power rivalry (U.S.-China).	Revolution or invasion.
7: Restructuring and Reset	Debt is restructured (often painfully); a new order emerges.	Potential 2026+: “Financial heart attack” forces rewrite of global finance.	Total paradigm shift.

Maximum Opportunity

Productivity Crisis

(Clearing out inneficient competitors)

+

Free Capital

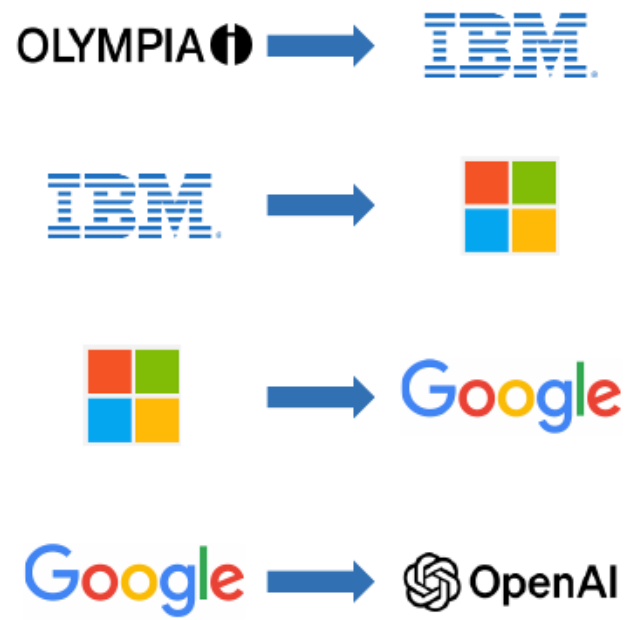
(Seeking new productive outlets)

+

Need for innovative Solutions

(Climate, Security, Demography, ...)

New technological frontier:



*These stages are most relevant for the financial markets and don’t necessarily dramatic societal events

You‘re in the perfect place to start!

Russia

Strategic overreach, 750K+ casualties, demographic collapse, isolated economy

USA

Constitutional stress test, DOGE chaos, potential wag-the-dog scenarios (Iran/Venezuela)

China

5 structural crises: demographics, real estate, deflation, debt, export dependency

Europe

Highest EU trust in 18 years, ReArm Europe, €600B+ defense commitment, strategic awakening

Why Now? The Perfect Convergence

Security Imperative

Russia's aggression forced defense spending. NATO 2% was a floor — now countries aim for 3-5%.

Tech Sovereignty Push

AI Act, Chips Act, Digital Markets Act — Europe is building regulatory frameworks that shape global standards.

Industrial Renaissance

Green Deal Industrial Plan, Critical Raw Materials Act, Net-Zero Industry Act — massive reshoring incentives.

Political Will

Highest EU approval ever. Citizens and leaders aligned on European sovereignty for the first time.

7 Strategic Playingfields

Where European entrepreneurs can build world-class companies

1 **Defense Tech**

2 **Energy Transition**

3 **AI & Sovereign Cloud**

4 **Critical Infrastructure**

5 **Health Tech**

6 **Space & Dual-Use**

7 **FinTech & Capital Markets**

Each playingfield has €10B+ in addressable market within Europe alone. The common thread: European regulation creates standards that the world adopts. Build compliant here, sell globally.

The Mindset Shift

Stop copying Silicon Valley. Start building European-style.

STOP	→	START
Copy US playbooks	→	Build for European strengths
Blitzscaling at all costs	→	Sustainable growth, real revenue
Move fast, break things	→	Build trust, earn regulation
Winner-take-all mindset	→	Ecosystem collaboration
Exit to US acquirer	→	Build European champions

Growing no-code and vibe-code market

The market forecasted to reach approximately USD 65 billion by 2027, with a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) over 30% from 2021 to 2028.

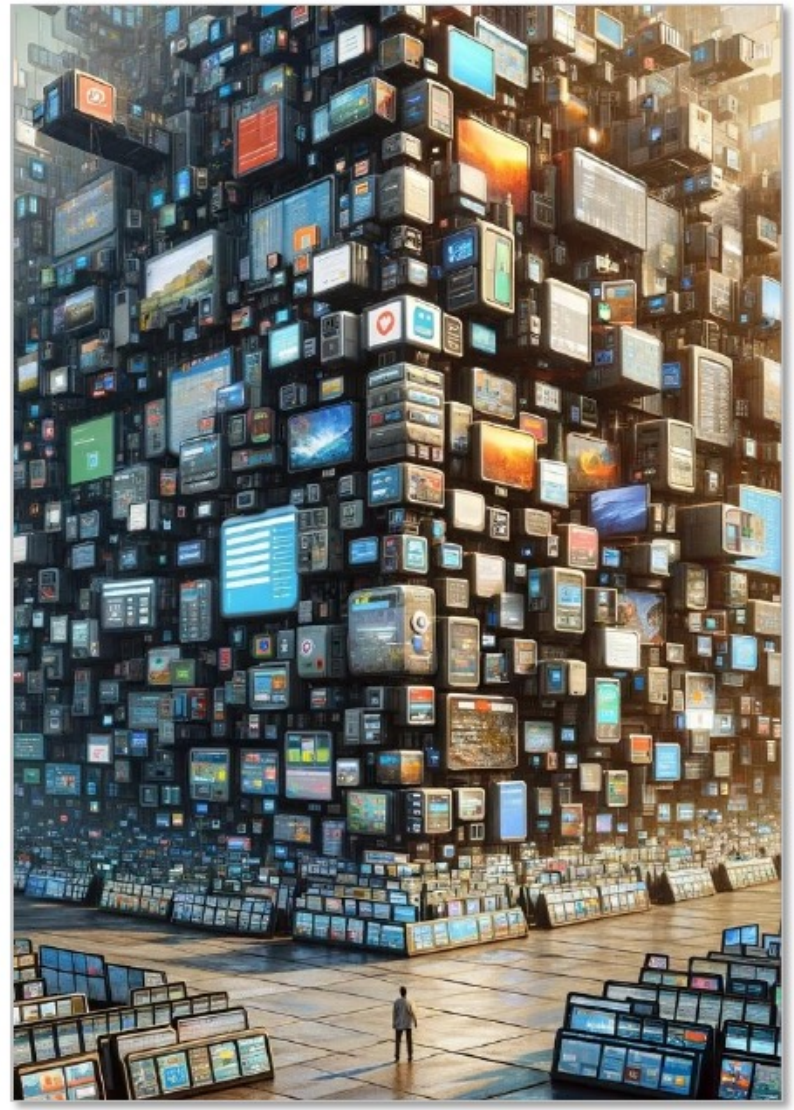
70% of new business applications will utilize low-code or no-code technologies by 2025, up from less than 25% in 2020.

Challenge: there are some generally helpful tools (Google Sheets, Airtable, Zapier, Make, Retool, ...) to model and automate business processes with little to no code.

For more, your specific choice highly depends on the problem you want to solve:

- Do you want to build a SaaS product?
- A mobile application?
- Selling a physical product?

There is no one-size-fits-all answer if you ask me (although platform operators usually try to make you believe that).



The AI Inflection Point

We're at a once-in-a-generation technology shift

AI reduces the cost of building software by 10-100x

A single developer can now do what took a team of 10

The barrier to entry has never been lower

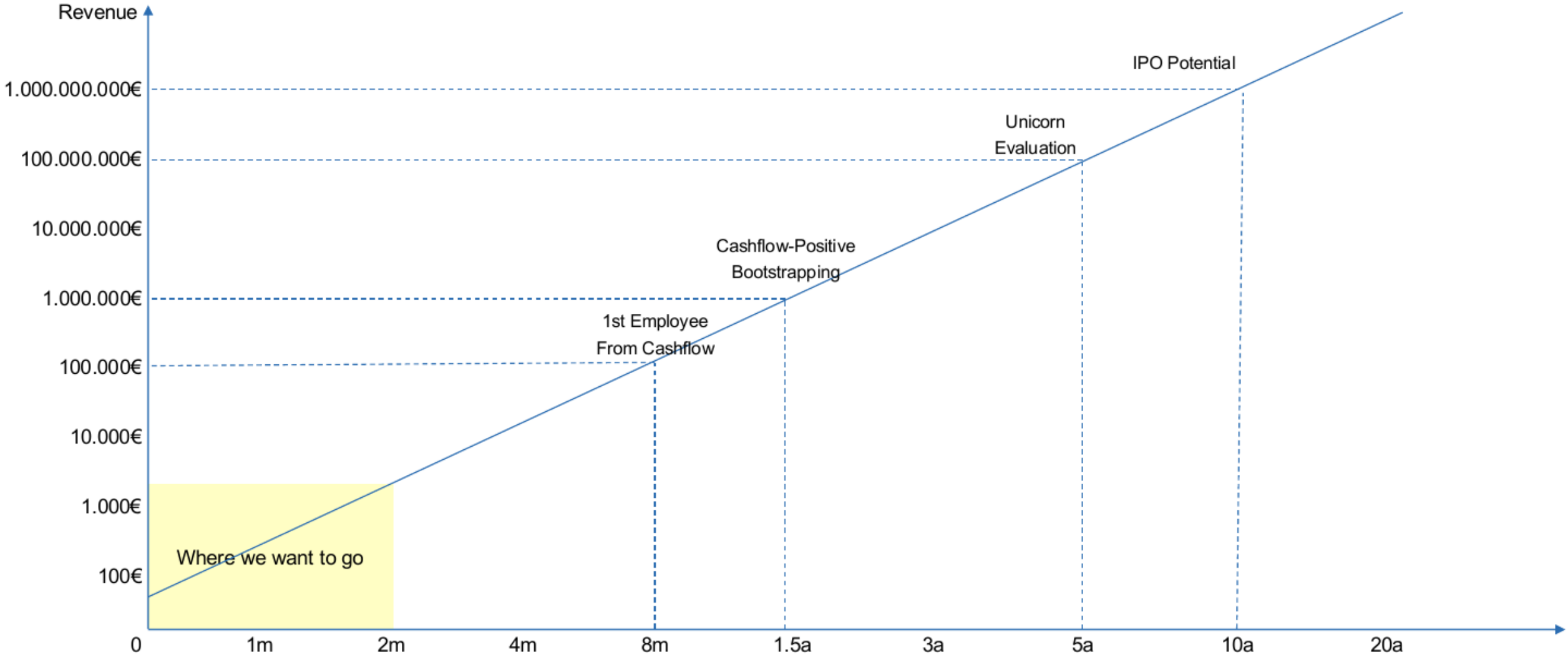
The opportunity has never been greater

McKinsey Global Institute, 2024: AI could add $4.4 trillion annually to the global economy

"In a world of AI, a single person can build what took an entire company. The playing field is more level than ever."

-- Marc Andreessen, a16z (2024)

Prepare for the long game*



Not scientific reason behind this chart

Speed matters:

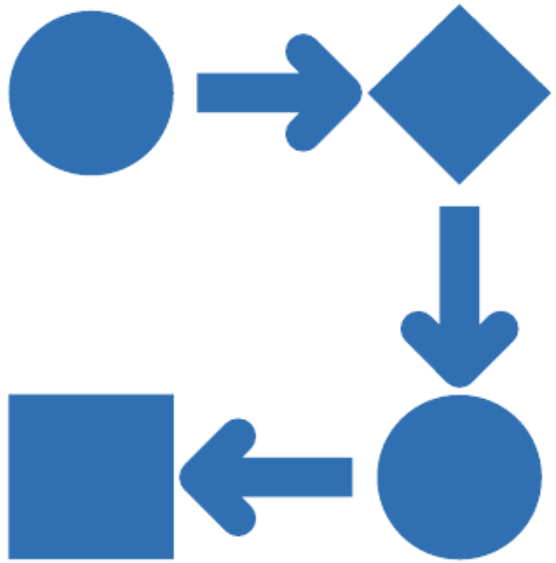
Ship Weekly

Goals

12 Weeks

From zero to your first 1,000 EUR in revenue

Your goal is not to write a business plan. It's to get paying customers.

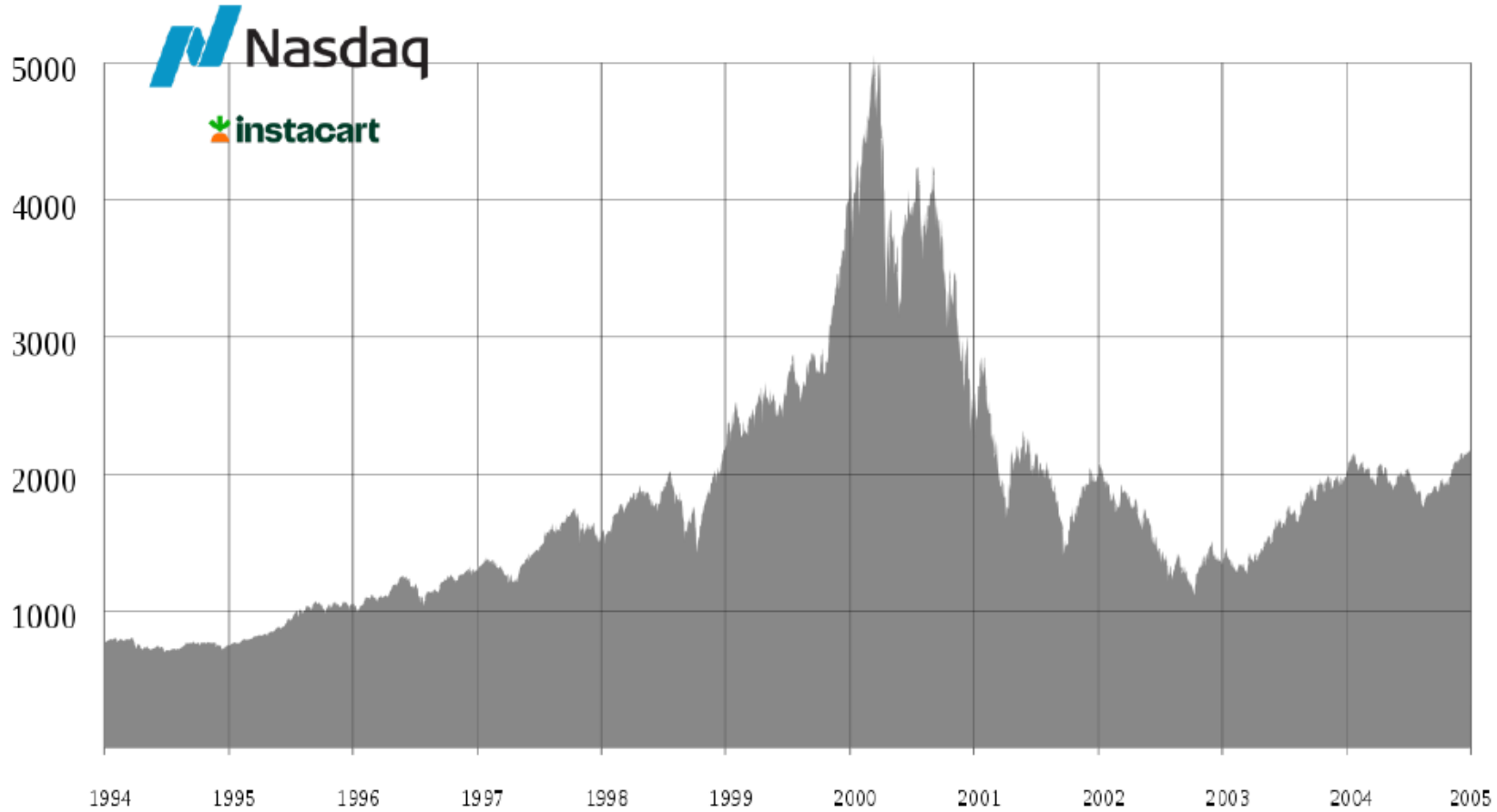


Your 12-Week Journey

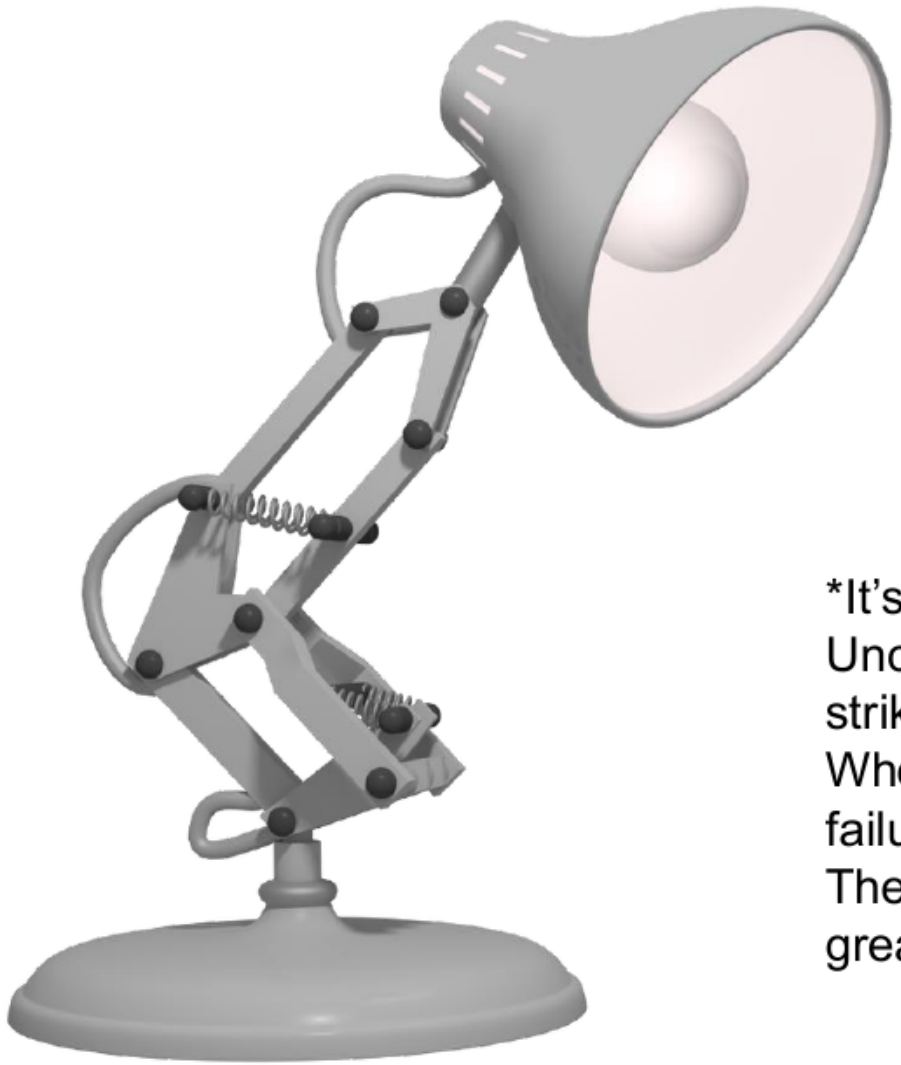
- Modules 1-4: IDEATION -- Find problems worth solving
- Modules 5-8: INCUBATION -- Validate with real users
- Modules 9-10: ACCELERATION – Convert your first customers
- Modules 10-12: GROWTH – Build for growth

What is a Startup?

Startups happened also before the internet, but they had a problem



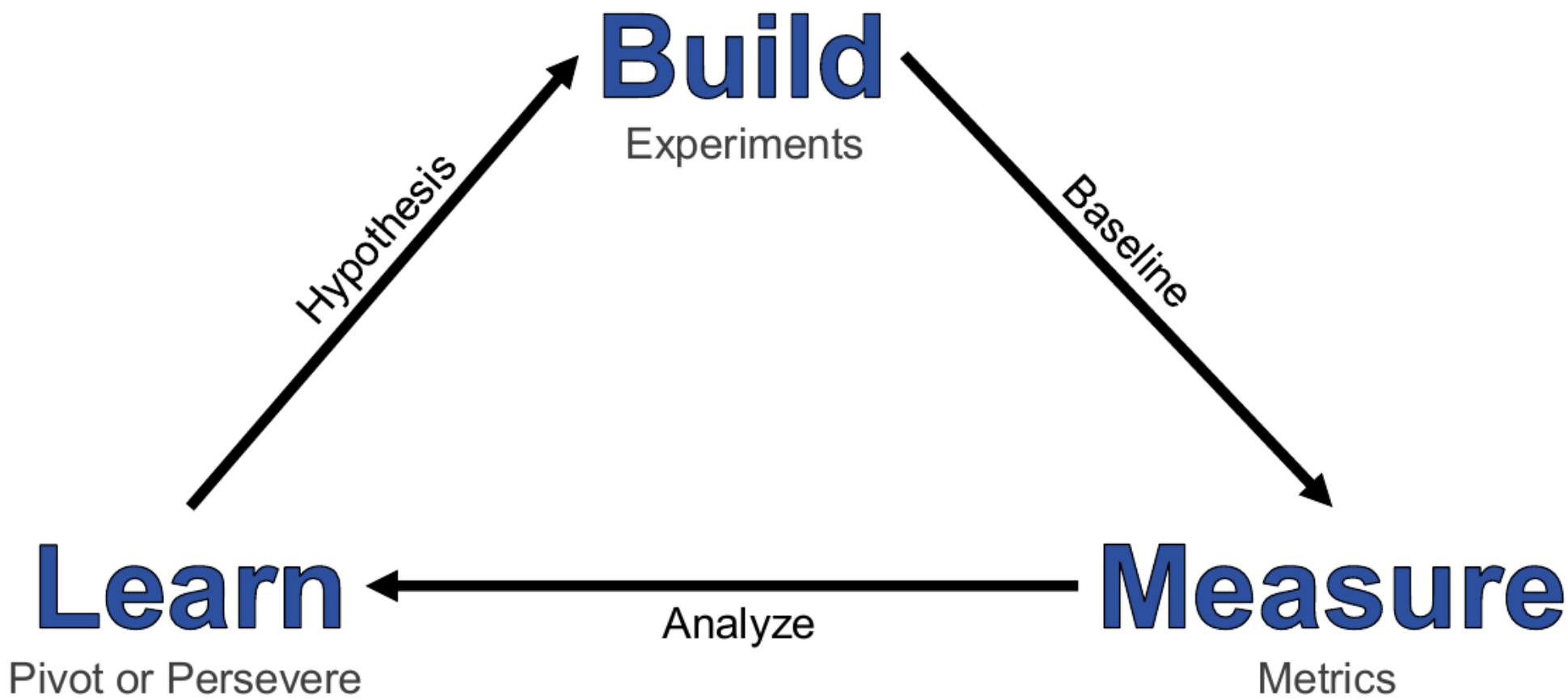
„Failure isn‘t a necessary evil“



*It’s a necessary consequence of doing something great. Uncouple fear and failure. Making mistakes should never strike fear into employees’ hearts.
When it comes to creative endeavours, a goal of zero failure is worse than useless. It is counterproductive. The truth is, the cost of preventing errors is often far greater than the cost of fixing them.

Ed Catmull: Creativity Inc.

The Build-Measure-Learn Loop



Erik Ries: The Lean Startup

The process of creating a venture is known

1. Market Segmentation
2. Select a Beachhead Market
3. Build an End User Profile
4. Calculate the TAM for the Beachhead
5. Profile the Persona for the Beachhead Market
6. Full Life Cycle Use Case
7. High-Level Product Specification
8. Quantify the Value Proposition
9. Identify Your Next 10 Customers
10. Define Your Core
11. Chart Your Competitive Position
12. Determine the Customer Organisation
13. Map the Process to Acquire a Paying Customer
14. Calculate the TOM for follow-on Markets
15. Design a Business Model
16. Set Your Pricing Framework
17. Calculate the Unit Economics
18. Map the Sales Process
19. Calculate the Customer Economics
20. Identify Key Assumptions
21. Test Key Assumptions
22. Define the MVP
23. Proof your Beachhead with your MVP
24. Develop a Product Plan

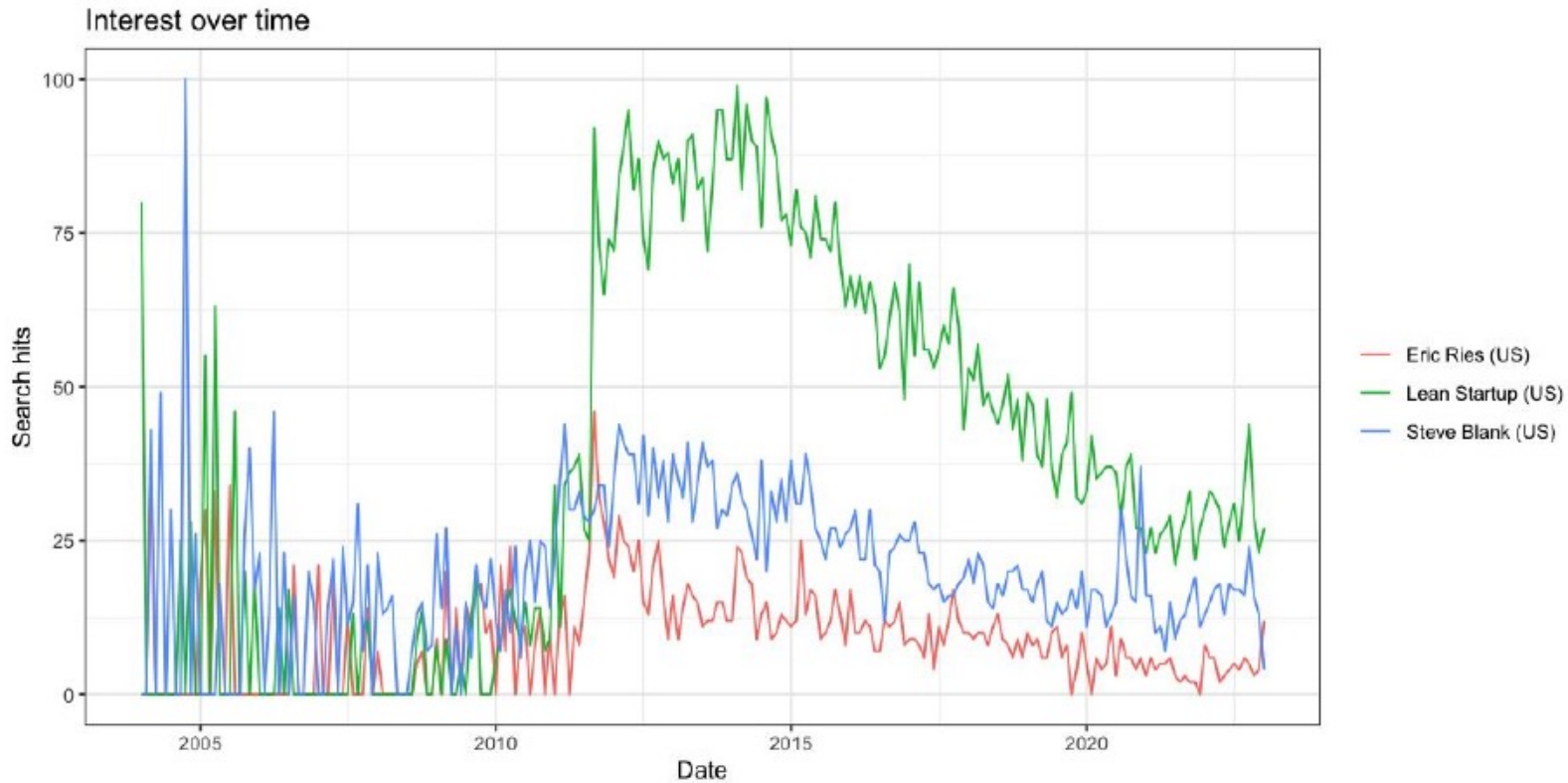
Bill Aulet: Disciplined Entrepreneurship

The process of creating a venture is known

1. Market Segmentation
2. Select a Beachhead Market
3. Build an End User Profile
4. Calculate the TAM for the Beachhead
5. Profile the Persona for the Beachhead Market
6. Full Life Cycle Use Case
7. High-Level Product Specification
8. Quantify the Value Proposition
9. Identify Your Next 10 Customers
10. Define Your Core
11. Chart Your Competitive Position
12. Determine the Customer Organisation
13. Map the Process to Acquire a Paying Customer
14. Calculate the TOM for follow-on Markets
15. Design a Business Model
16. Set Your Pricing Framework
17. Calculate the Unit Economics
18. Map the Sales Process
19. Calculate the Customer Economics
20. Identify Key Assumptions
21. Test Key Assumptions
22. Define the MVP
23. Proof your Beachhead with your MVP
24. Develop a Product Plan



Thus, we received the Lean Startup



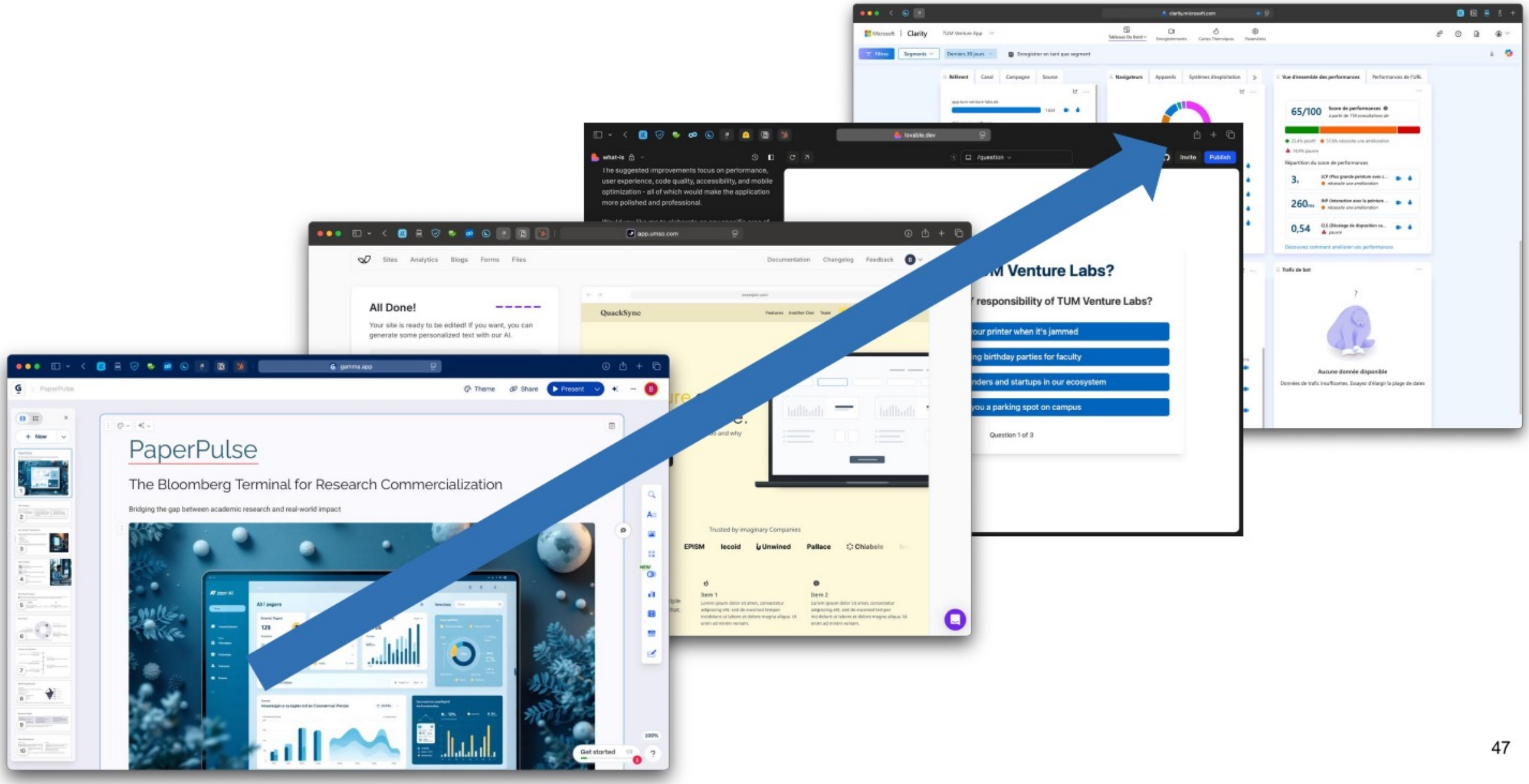
	Dependent variable:
	SURVIVAL RATE
β_{treat}	4.87^{***}
	(2.77, 6.97)
β_{post}	0.18
	(−2.53, 2.90)
$\beta_{interaction}$	1.02
	(−2.82, 4.86)
β_0	74.21^{***}
	(72.72, 75.69)
Observations	60
R^2	0.38
Adjusted R^2	0.34
Residual Std. Error	3.48 (df = 56)
F Statistic	11.34^{***} (df = 3; 56)
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Heumann, Burger (2023)

Speed matters:

Ship Weekly

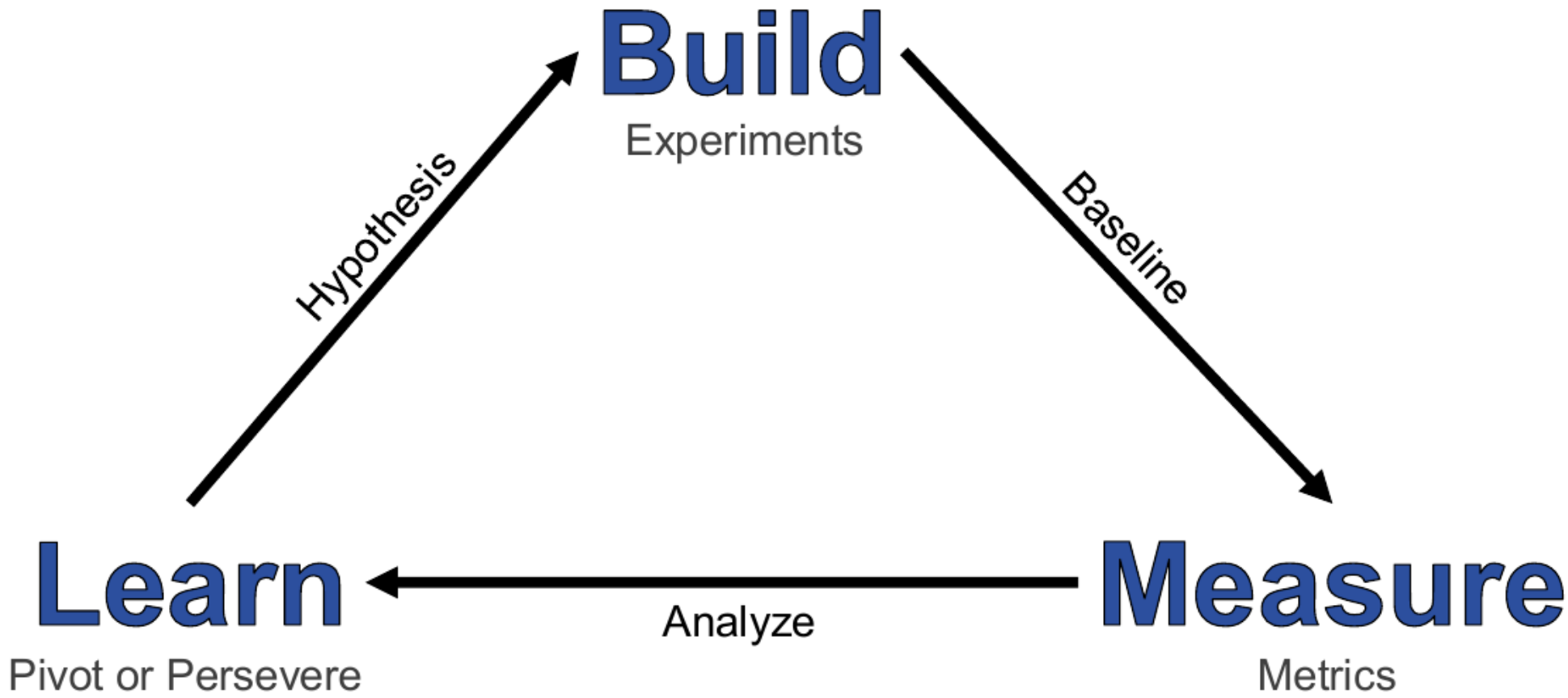
We will walk you from concept to landing-page, to product, to revenue



Every week, you can talk to at least

15 relevant users

The Build-Measure-Learn Loop

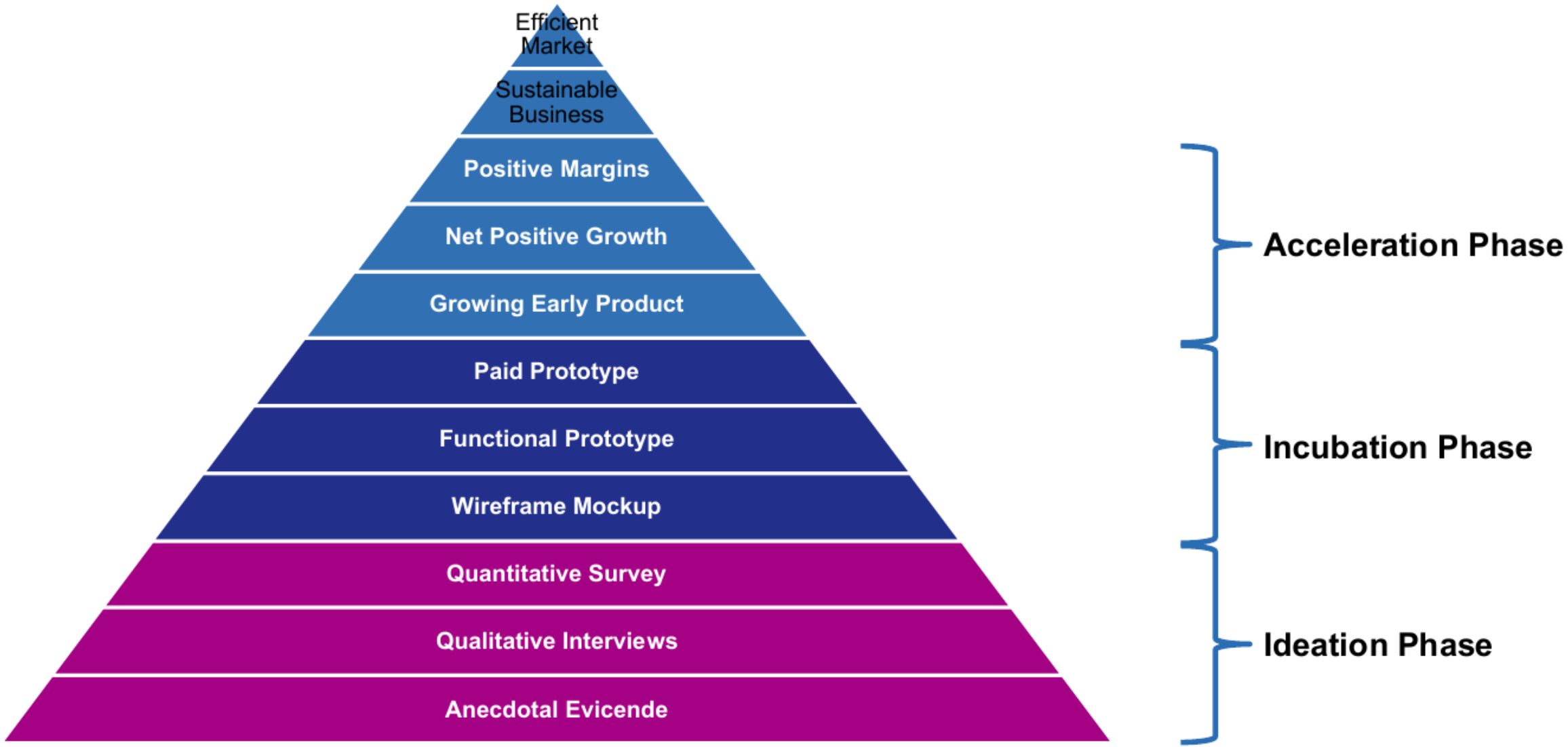



OFFERS

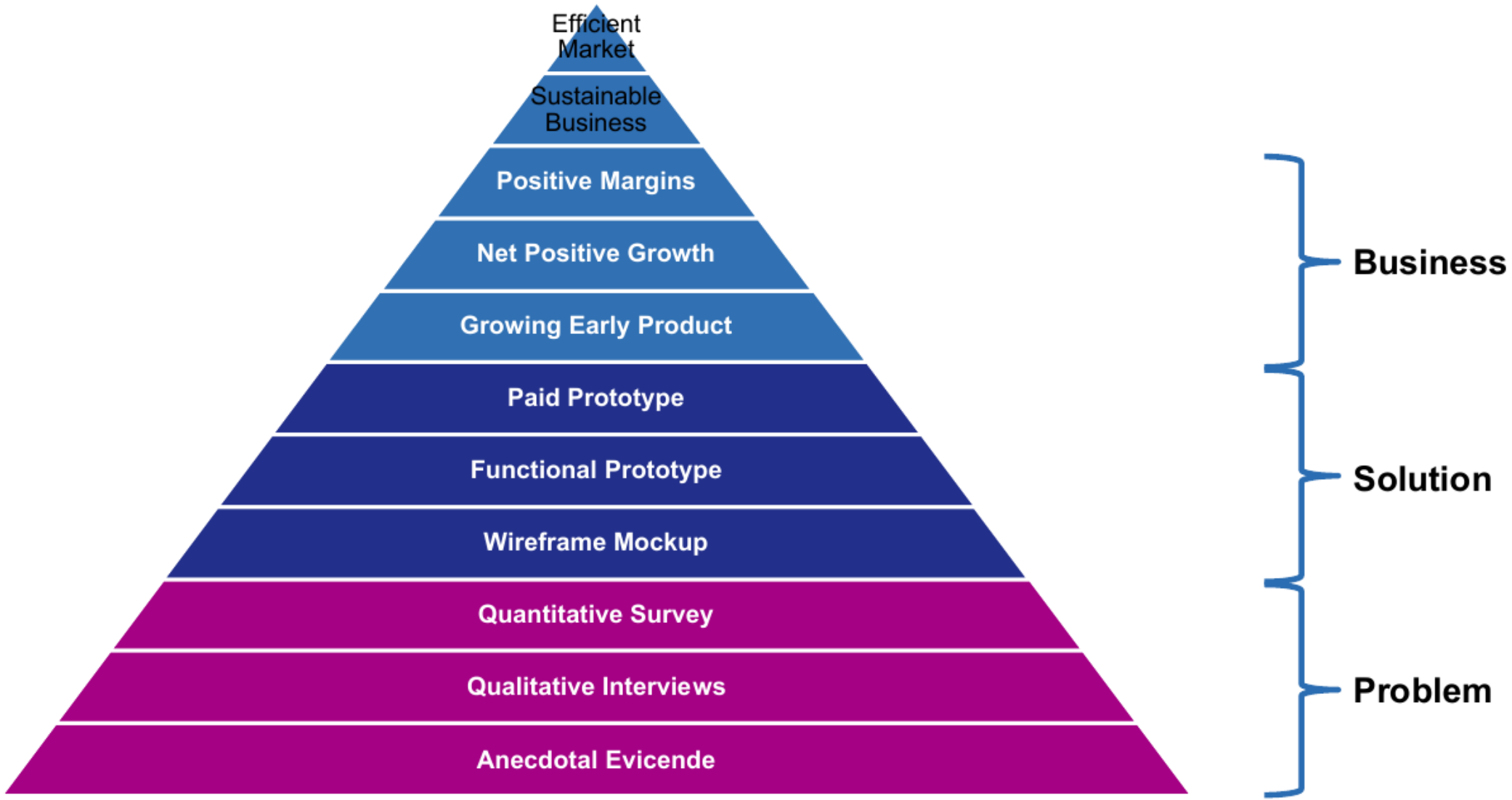

AIR
GUINNESS
DRAUGHT
blk.
NEEDS

One iteration should not take more thank 4 hours

Hirarchy of evidence in the lean startup



Hirarchy of evidence in the lean startup

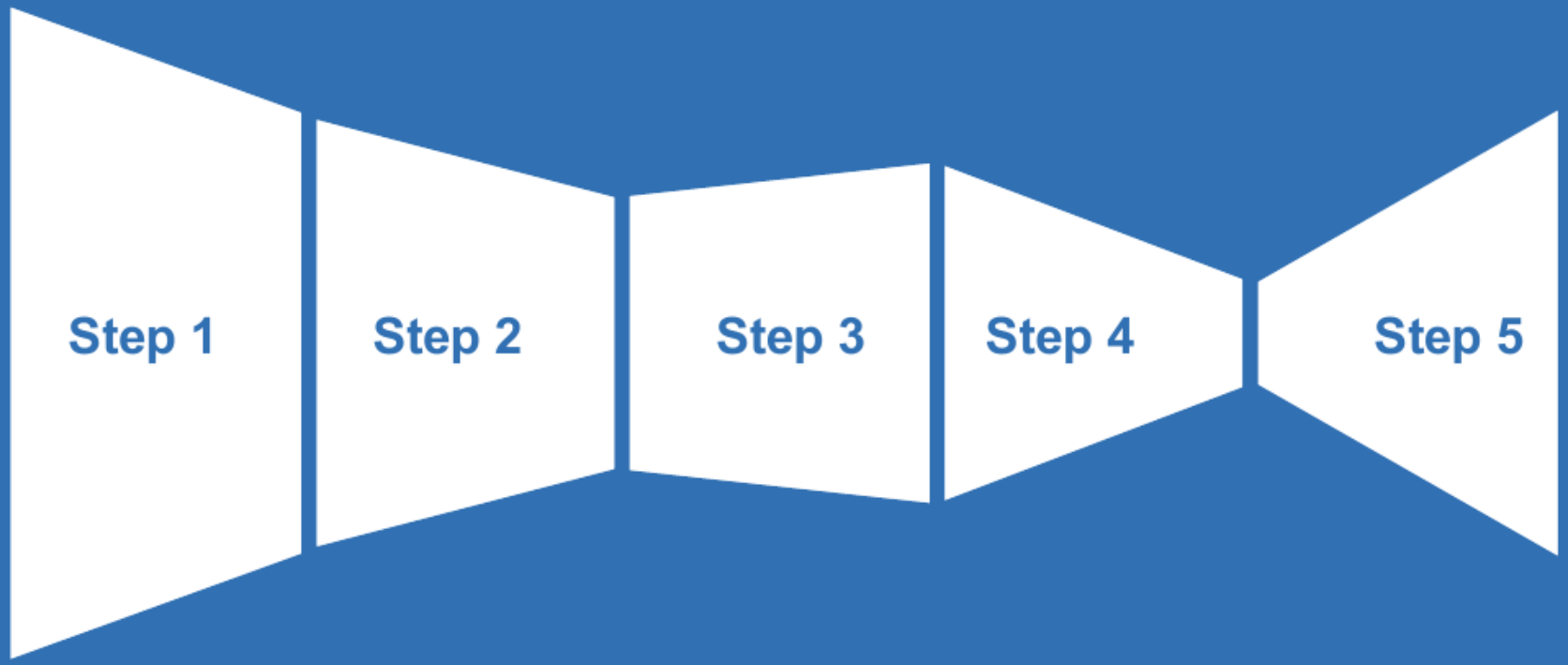


Understanding working with constraints

No Manpower
No Money
No Time

BUT

No Inertia
No Legacy
No Politics



Desired Output

Comare: Eliyahu M. Goldratt: The Goal


IT'S DANGEROUS TO GO
ALONE! TAKE THIS.

"The most important quality in a founder is not intelligence, it's relentless resourcefulness."

-- Paul Graham, 'Relentlessly Resourceful' (2009)

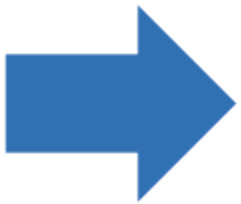
Why should I need a founding team? Teams—not ideas—are the best predictors of startup success.

Pros: Founding Teams

- **Higher survival rates**: Teams demonstrate better venture survival than solo founders. **Over 80% of companies that successfully secured Series-A funding rounds had more than one founder.**
- **Complementary skills**: Diverse expertise covers technical, business, and market knowledge gaps.
- **Resource mobilization**: Teams can leverage broader networks and funding opportunities.
- **Risk sharing**: Shared decision-making and workload distribution reduces individual burden.
- **VC preference**: Investors consistently favor complete founding teams over solo entrepreneurs. **90% of startups funded by top venture capital firms have a founding team.**
- **Validation**: Multiple perspectives improve strategic decision-making and problem-solving.

Pros: Solo Founders

- **Full control**: Complete autonomy over strategic decisions and company direction.
- **Speed**: Faster decision-making without need for consensus building.
- **Equity retention**: No dilution from co-founder shares.
- **Strategic cocreators**: Can leverage advisors, contractors, and partners without giving up equity.
- **Crisis resilience**: Solo founders show persistence during uncertain times.
- **But: Female solo founders experience the lowest survival rates.**



Founding is hard enough as it is. Share the mental- and work-load!

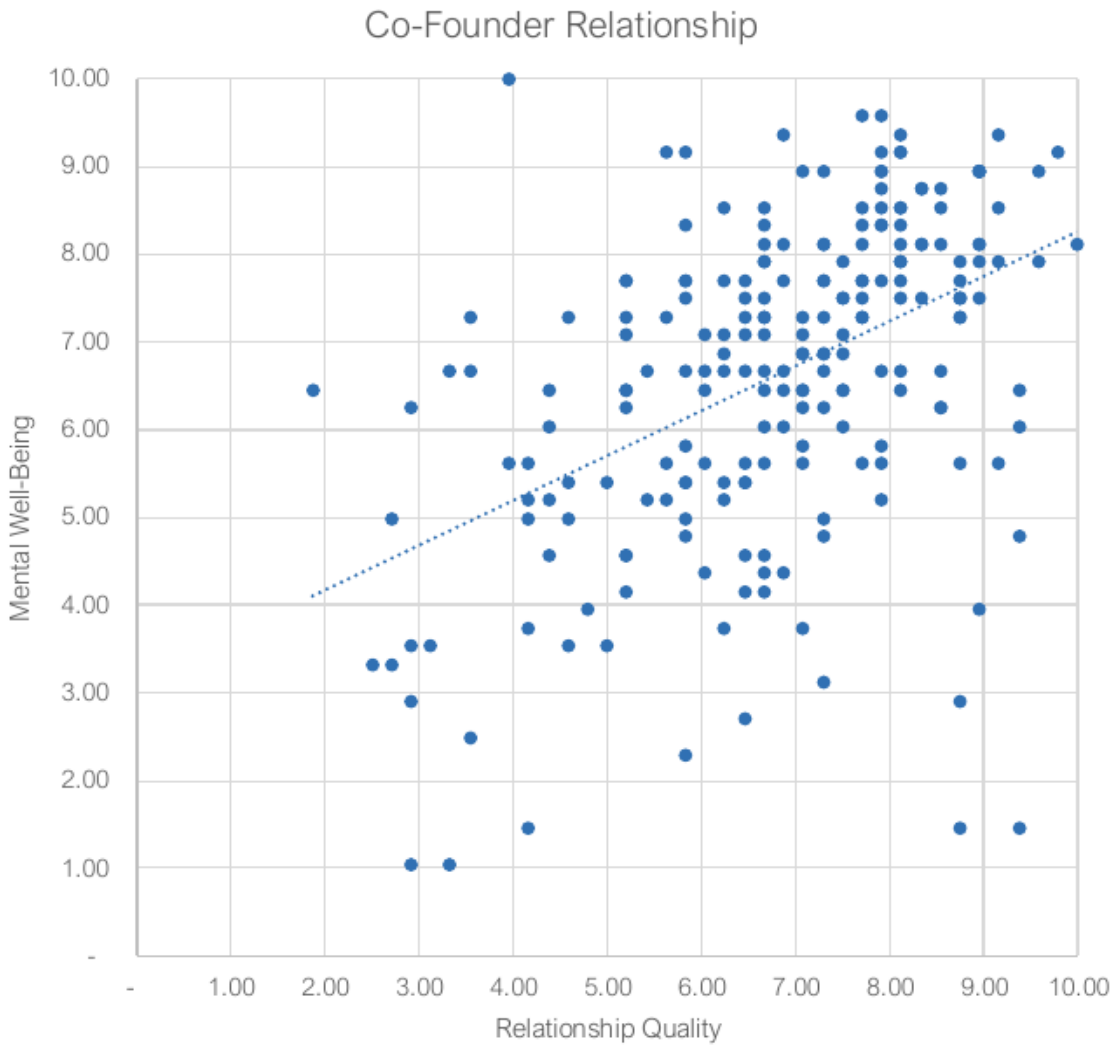
The **ideal founding team has 2-4 members**

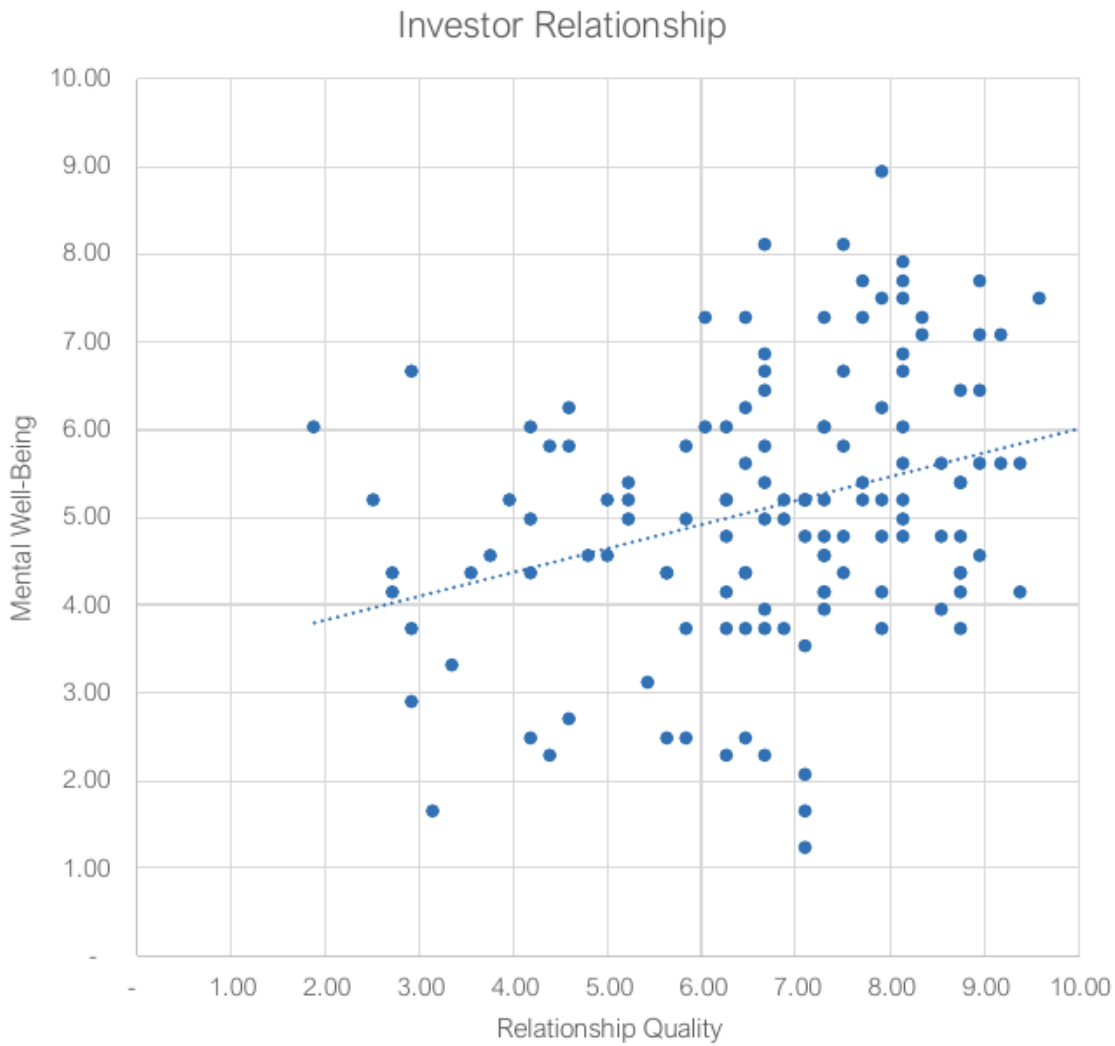

Supreme
Product
Sales

Tech



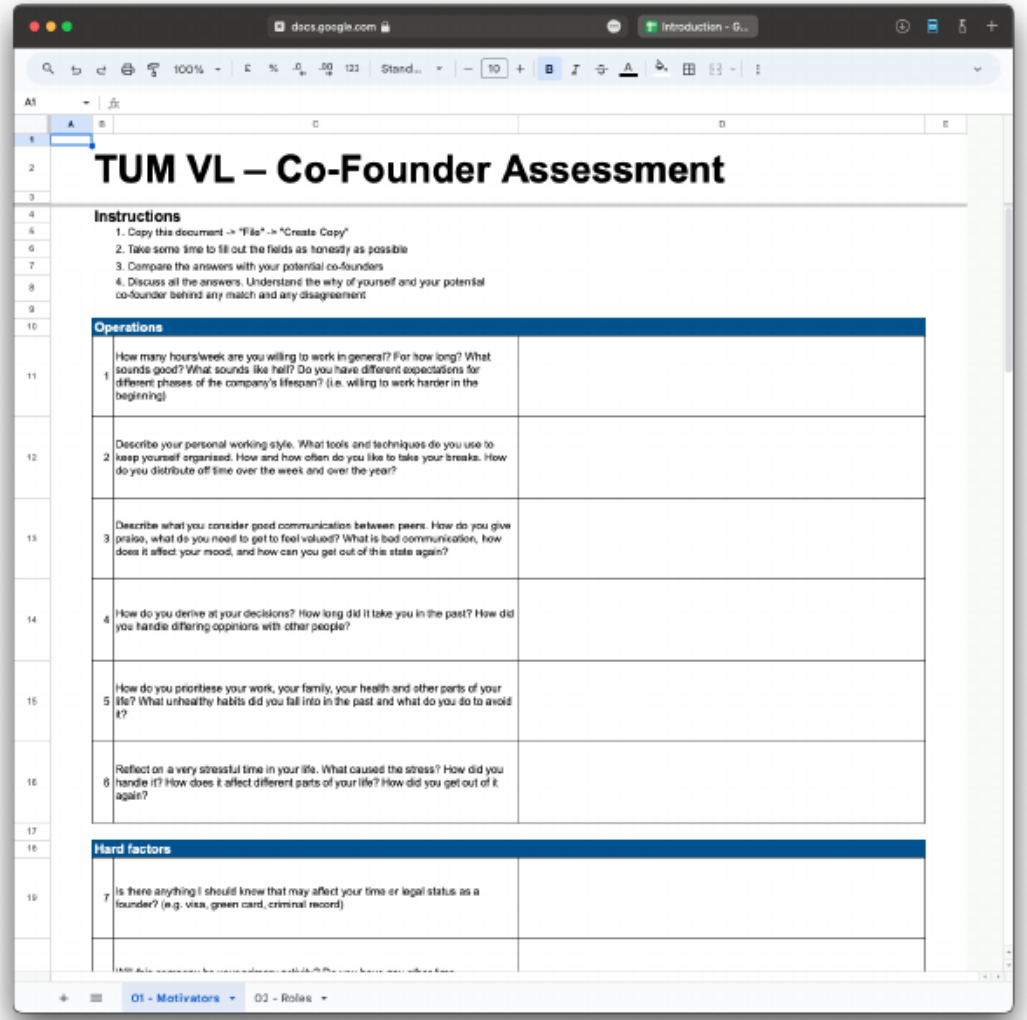
Some Science[10] (just for context)





[10] Burger 2023

There is no best practice to finding a co-founder, but some ideas to help



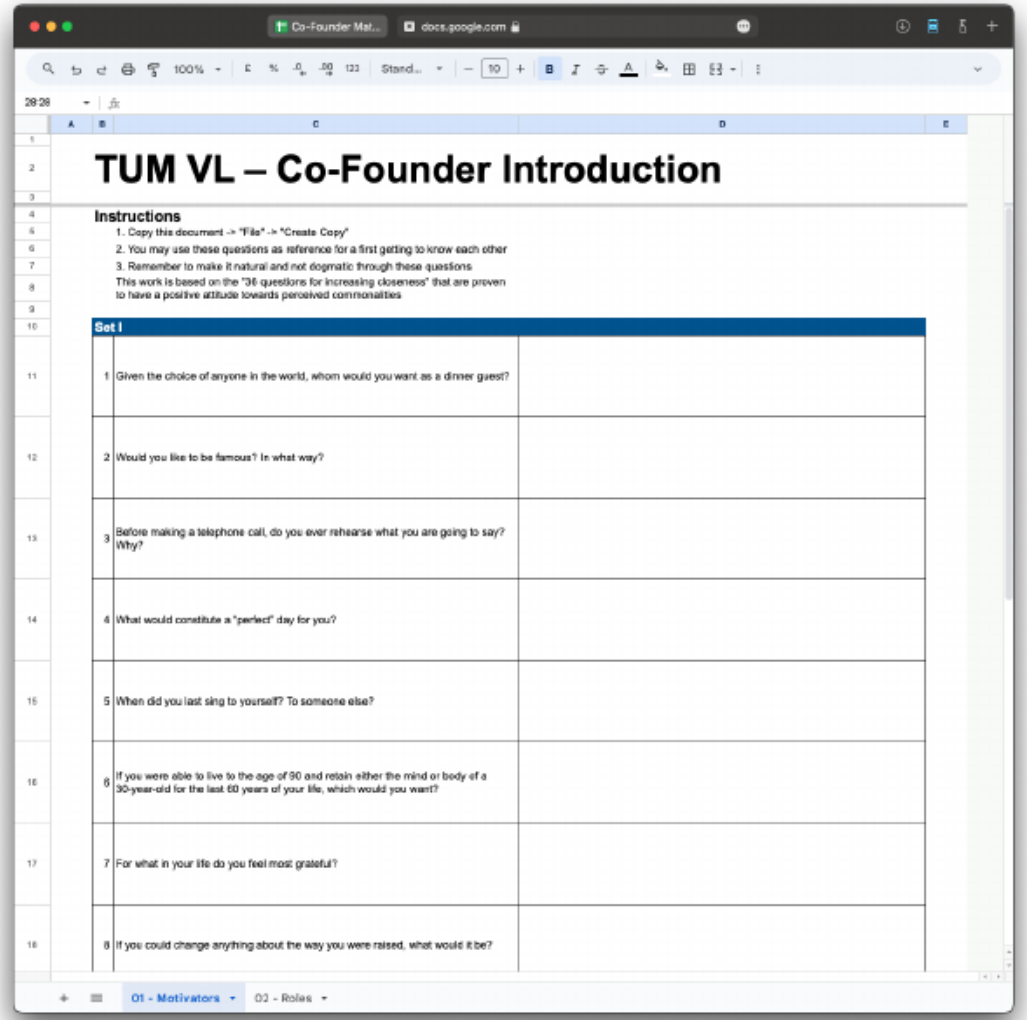
TUM VL – Co-Founder Assessment

Instructions

1. Copy this document -> "File" -> "Create Copy"
2. Take some time to fill out the fields as honestly as possible
3. Compare the answers with your potential co-founders
4. Discuss all the answers. Understand the why of yourself and your potential co-founder behind any match and any disagreement

Operations		
1	How many hours/week are you willing to work in general? For how long? What sounds good? What sounds like hell? Do you have different expectations for different phases of the company's lifespan? (i.e. willing to work harder in the beginning)	
2	Describe your personal working style. What tools and techniques do you use to keep yourself organised. How and how often do you like to take your breaks. How do you distribute off time over the week and over the year?	
3	Describe what you consider good communication between peers. How do you give praise, what do you need to get to feel valued? What is bad communication, how does it affect your mood, and how can you get out of this state again?	
4	How do you derive at your decisions? How long did it take you in the past? How did you handle differing opinions with other people?	
5	How do you prioritiese your work, your family, your health and other parts of your life? What unhealthy habits did you fall into in the past and what do you do to avoid it?	
6	Reflect on a very stressful time in your life. What caused the stress? How did you handle it? How does it affect different parts of your life? How did you get out of it again?	

Hard factors		
7	Is there anything I should know that may affect your time or legal status as a founder? (e.g. visa, green card, criminal record)	



TUM VL – Co-Founder Introduction

Instructions

1. Copy this document -> "File" -> "Create Copy"
2. You may use these questions as reference for a first getting to know each other
3. Remember to make it natural and not dogmatic through these questions

This work is based on the "36 questions for increasing closeness" that are proven to have a positive attitude towards perceived commonalities

Set I		
1	Given the choice of anyone in the world, whom would you want as a dinner guest?	
2	Would you like to be famous? In what way?	
3	Before making a telephone call, do you ever rehearse what you are going to say? Why?	
4	What would constitute a "perfect" day for you?	
5	When did you last sing to yourself? To someone else?	
6	If you were able to live to the age of 90 and retain either the mind or body of a 30-year-old for the last 60 years of your life, which would you want?	
7	For what in your life do you feel most grateful?	
8	If you could change anything about the way you were raised, what would it be?	

Building Your Team Culture

A joint initiative by

Psychological Safety: The #1 Factor

180+
teams studied

2 years
of research

#1 Factor
Psychological Safety

Teams where members feel safe to take risks consistently outperform

Safe to admit mistakes, ask questions, and propose wild ideas

Your job as a founder: Create an environment where truth can be spoken

Google re:Work, 2015: 'What Google Learned From Its Quest to Build the Perfect Team' (Project Aristotle)

Note that this framework is highly culture Sensitive (Meyer)

FIGURE 2.2. **EVALUATING**

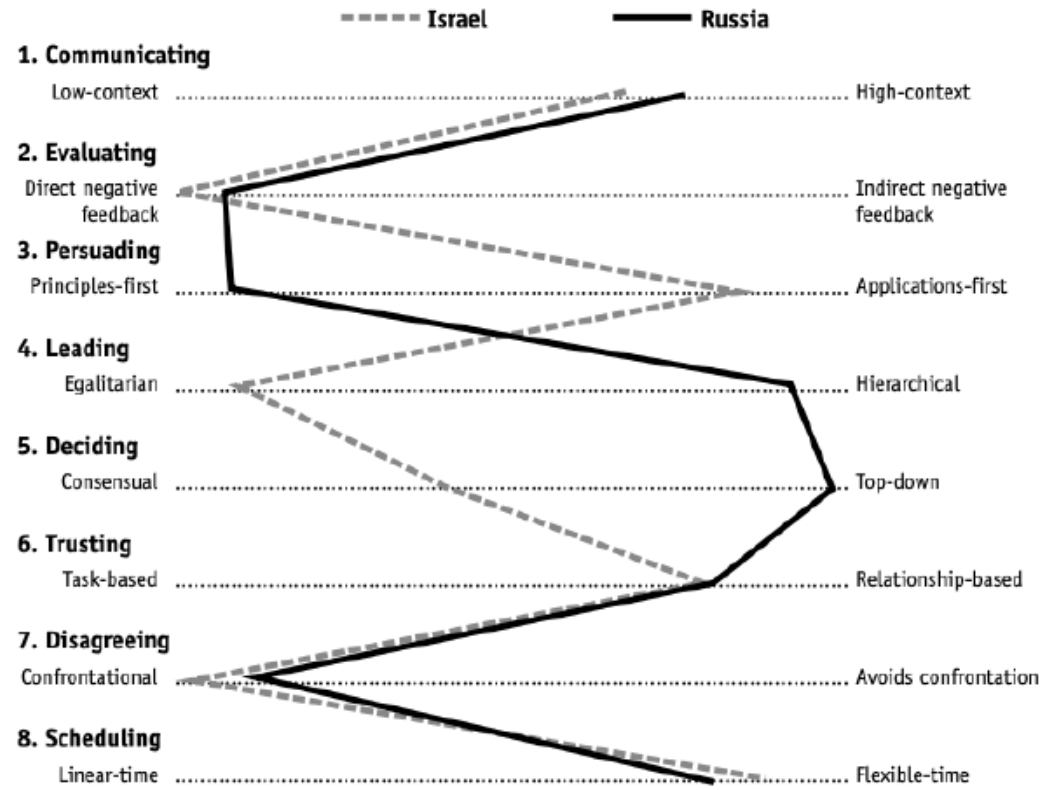
Russia France Italy US UK Brazil India Saudi Arabia Japan
Israel Germany Norway Australia Canada Mexico China Korea Thailand
Netherlands Denmark Spain Argentina Kenya Ghana Indonesia

Direct negative feedback — **Indirect negative feedback**

Direct negative feedback: Negative feedback to a colleague is provided frankly, bluntly, honestly. Negative messages stand alone, not softened by positive ones. Absolute descriptors are often used (totally inappropriate, completely unprofessional) when criticizing. Criticism may be given to an individual in front of a group.

Indirect negative feedback: Negative feedback to a colleague is provided softly, subtly, diplomatically. Positive messages are used to wrap negative ones. Qualifying descriptors are often used (sort of inappropriate, slightly unprofessional) when criticizing. Criticism is given only in private.

FIGURE I.1.



Workshop: Strengthen your team

WORKSHOP

Team Foundation Sprint

5 min

Personal Standups

Each member: What's your superpower? What drains you? What do you need from this team?

10 min

Team Charter

Agree on: communication channel, meeting rhythm, decision-making rule, what 'done' means for you.

10 min

Working Agreement

Write down 5 non-negotiable team norms. Sign it. This is your team constitution.

30 min

Get to Know each other

Just take some time to get to know your teammates and classmates, not particular deliverable

STEP 1

Personal Standups (5 min)

Each team member answers three questions (1 minute each):

1

What's your superpower?

What are you genuinely great at? Technical skill, people skill, domain knowledge?

2

What drains your energy?

What tasks do you dread? Admin, cold calls, ambiguity, conflict?

3

What do you need from this team?

Honesty? Structure? Space to experiment? Fast decisions?

Listen actively. No interrupting. Take notes — you'll need them for the charter.

STEP 2

Team Charter (10 min)

Agree on the basics. Write them down. This is your operating system.

Communication Channel

Where do we talk? (Slack, WhatsApp, Discord?) When do we respond? (24h rule? Same-day?)

Meeting Rhythm

How often do we meet? (Weekly standup? Daily check-in?) How long? Who sets the agenda?

Decision-Making

Who decides what? (Consensus? One owner per domain? Majority vote?) What's the default if we can't agree?

Definition of Done

When is a task 'done'? (Shipped? Reviewed? Tested with a user?) How do we track progress?

STEP 3

Working Agreement (10 min)

Write 5 non-negotiable team norms. Sign them. This is your team constitution.

1. We respond to messages within 24 hours.
2. We tell each other when something isn't working — using DESC.
3. Decisions are made by the domain owner. If unclear, we vote. Ties go to action.
4. We show up prepared. If you can't, say so 24h in advance.
5. We celebrate wins and own failures as a team — no blame.

These are examples — write YOUR norms. Make them specific to your team.

You‘re in the perfect storm…

Ray Dalio‘s model for financial life cycles*:

Stage	Description	U.S. Timeline Example	Key Risks
1: New Order Established	A post-war reset crowns a new reserve currency and global leader, fostering stability.	1944 Bretton Woods Agreement: USD becomes world reserve after WWII.	None—honeymoon phase.
2: Peace and Productive Debt	Borrowing fuels innovation and growth; prosperity blooms.	1950s–1960s: Post-war boom, infrastructure investments.	Over-reliance on easy credit.
3: Debt Bubble and Wealth Gap	Excessive borrowing inflates assets; inequality surges as inflation erodes purchasing power for the masses.	1970s–2000s: Housing/credit boom widens the rich-poor divide.	Social unrest from disparity.
4: Bubble Burst and Downturn	Debt implodes, triggering recession.	2008 Financial Crisis: Subprime meltdown.	Systemic contagion.
5: Money Printing and Debasement	Central banks flood the system with liquidity (e.g., QE), but it widens gaps and erodes currency value.	2008–2020: Trillions printed; inflation hits the vulnerable hardest.	Currency devaluation, asset bubbles.
6: Internal Conflict and External Wars	Populism rises; civil strife weakens the empire, inviting rivals.	2020s onward: Polarization, tariffs, and great-power rivalry (U.S.-China).	Revolution or invasion.
7: Restructuring and Reset	Debt is restructured (often painfully); a new order emerges.	Potential 2026+: “Financial heart attack” forces rewrite of global finance.	Total paradigm shift.

Maximum Opportunity

Productivity Crisis

(Clearing out inneficient competitors)

+

Free Capital

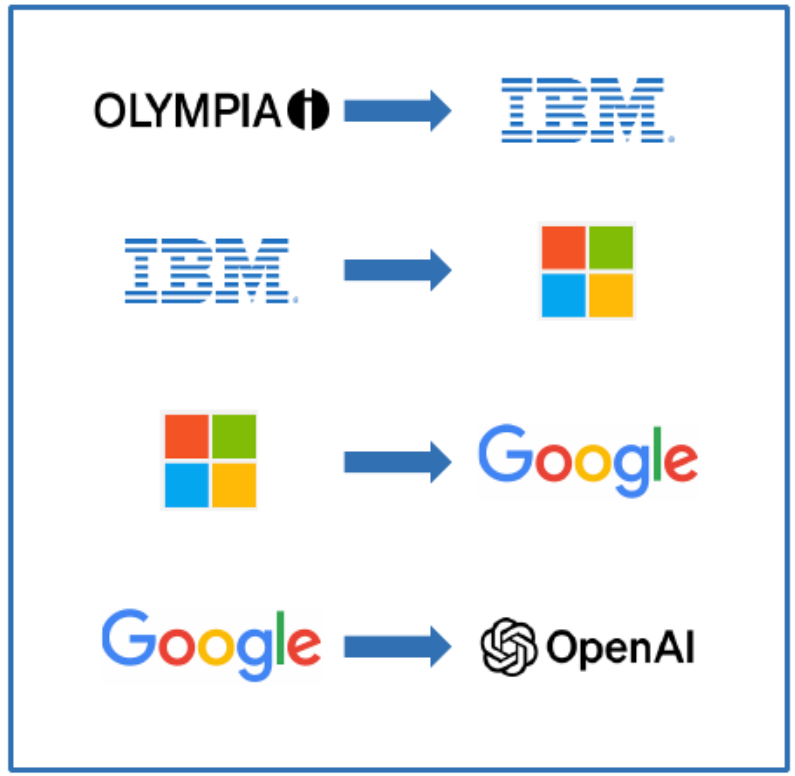
(Seeking new productive outlets)

+

Need for innovative Solutions

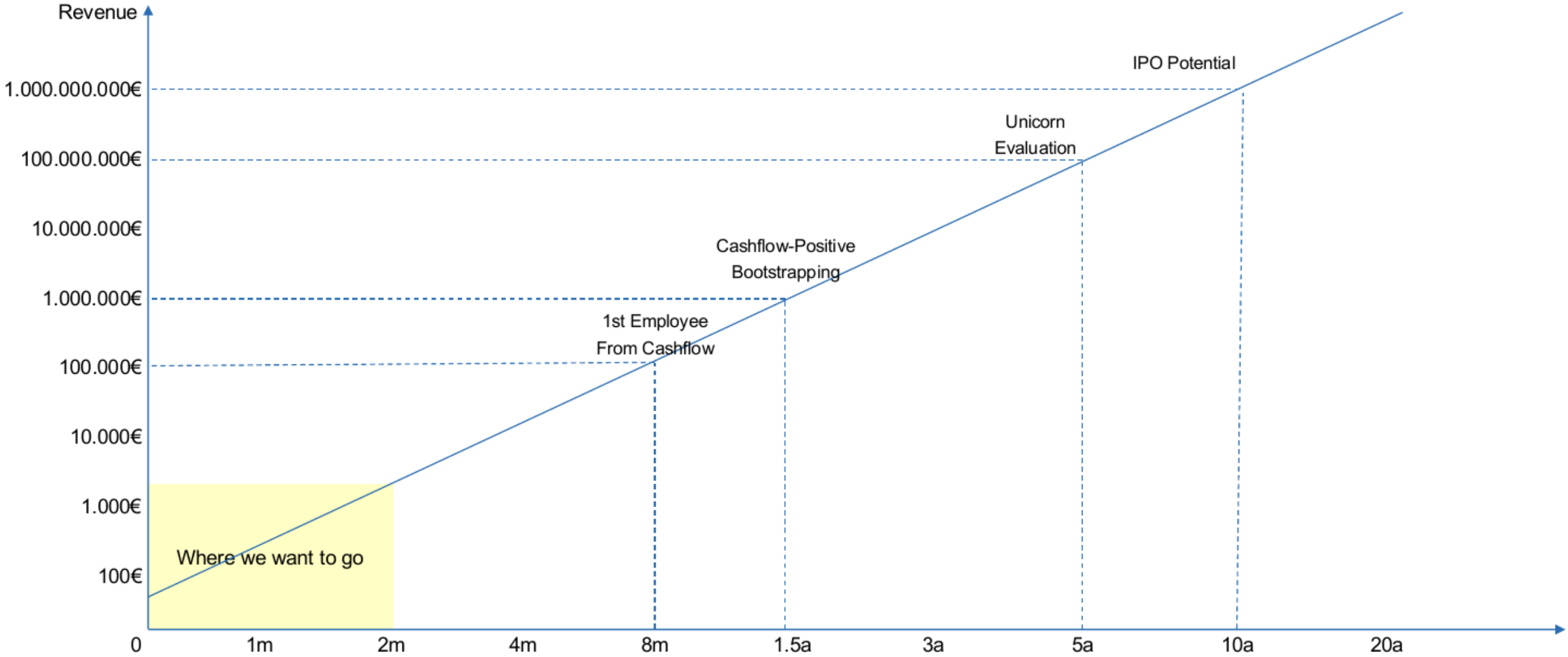
(Climate, Security, Demography, …)

New technological frontier:



*These stages are most relevant for the financial markets and don’t necessarily dramatic societal events

But it will take time.



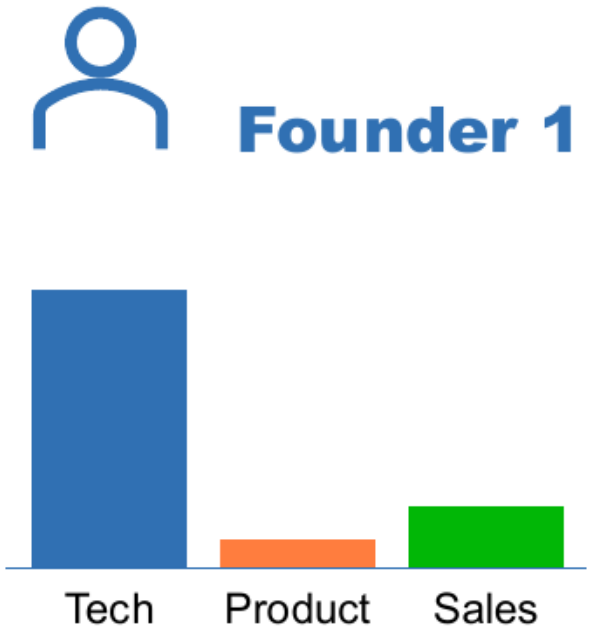
Not scientific reason behind this chart

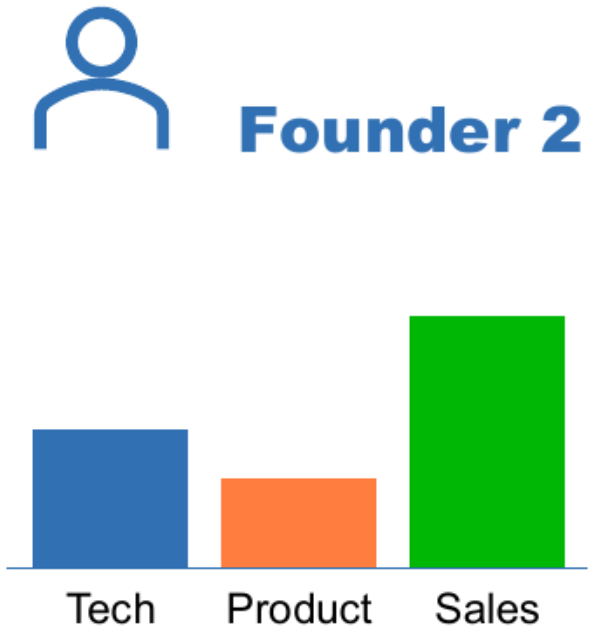
And you need to know which game you are playing.

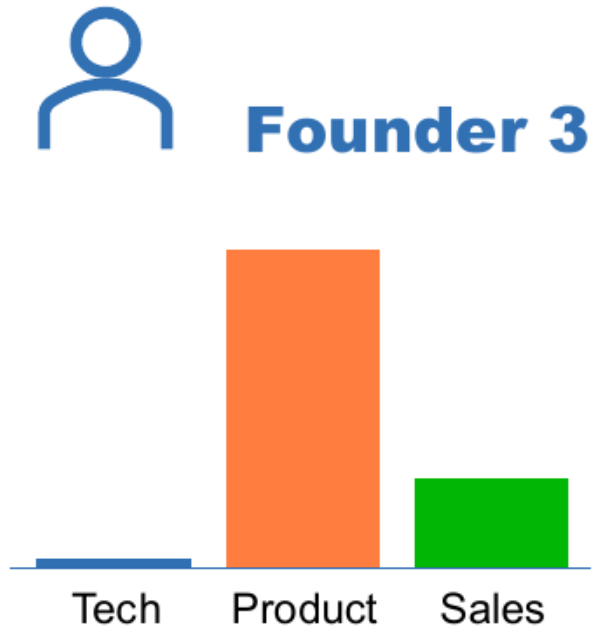




Build a team that is up to the task







Reflection: The Process – Man vs. Machine

Where did AI actually help you?



Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?



Assignment for home work

1. Finalize your Team Charter
2. Each team member: Find 3 problems you personally experience
3. Brainstorm in your team about problems you know of or have
4. Decide on what kind of organization you want to create

Thank You!

A joint initiative by